

CORTORA

Standard Operating Procedure for Payment Case Investigation

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This Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) describes how Payments Specialists, Payments Operations staff, and OpsPilot should investigate and resolve payment-related cases, including duplicate charges, failed authorizations, captured-but-cancelled orders, and reconciliation exceptions. It complements, and does not replace, the Refund Policy, which governs whether a refund is owed.

1. Payment Lifecycle

A payment transaction in Cortora's systems moves through the following statuses:

Status	Meaning
AUTHORIZING	The payment provider is validating the customer's payment method; no funds have moved.
AUTHORIZED	Funds are reserved but not yet captured; capture typically occurs when the order enters PROCESSING.
CAPTURED	Funds have been collected from the customer.
FAILED	The authorization or capture attempt was declined or errored.
REFUNDED	The full captured amount has been returned to the customer.
PARTIALLY_REFUNDED	Part of the captured amount has been returned; a balance remains captured.
CHARGEBACK_INITIATED	The customer's bank has raised a dispute; see the Chargeback Handling SOP.

2. General Investigation Principles

- Always retrieve the payment transaction history for the relevant order before forming a conclusion; never infer payment status from the customer's description alone.
- Distinguish between an authorization and a capture — a customer who sees a pending charge on their bank statement may be looking at an AUTHORIZED transaction that will never be captured.
- Compare transaction amounts, timestamps, and payment method fingerprints when checking for duplicates; two transactions of different amounts are not automatically a duplicate charge.
- Confirm the order status alongside the payment status — a CAPTURED payment against a CANCELLED order is a distinct exception from a CAPTURED payment against an active order.

3. Duplicate or Erroneous Charge Investigation

Follow these steps when a customer reports being charged more than once for what they believe is a single order:

- Retrieve all payment transactions linked to the order identifier provided by the customer.

- Identify whether two or more transactions share the same amount and a capture timestamp within a short window of each other.
- Rule out the possibility that the customer placed two separate orders — check for two distinct order identifiers before concluding a true duplicate exists.
- If a genuine duplicate CAPTURED transaction is confirmed, apply the Refund Policy to refund the duplicate transaction only, leaving the original order's legitimate payment intact.
- Record the transaction identifiers of both the retained and refunded transactions in the case.

4. Failed Authorization and Payment Retry

When a payment authorization fails, the order remains in PENDING and the customer should be given the opportunity to retry with the same or a different payment method. Cortora allows up to three authorization attempts within a 24-hour window before the order is automatically cancelled under the Cancellation Policy. A Support Agent should never manually mark an order as paid to work around a failed authorization; only the payment service can transition a transaction to CAPTURED.

5. Captured-but-Cancelled Orders

This exception occurs when an order is cancelled after its payment has already been captured, typically due to a timing gap between fulfillment cancellation and payment capture. The employee should confirm the order status is genuinely CANCELLED, confirm the payment status is CAPTURED, and then apply the Refund Policy to issue a full refund of the captured amount. This case type should always trigger a refund evaluation automatically; it should not require the customer to notice and report the discrepancy.

6. Payment Reconciliation Exceptions

Reconciliation exceptions arise when Cortora's internal payment records do not match the payment provider's settlement records — for example, a transaction recorded as CAPTURED internally but not present in the provider's settlement file, or vice versa. These exceptions should be escalated to Payments Operations rather than resolved directly with the customer, since they may indicate a system integration fault rather than a customer-specific issue. A case should remain in INVESTIGATING status until the discrepancy is explained, not resolved by assumption.

7. Refund Execution

- Confirm eligibility and amount under the Refund Policy before initiating execution.
- Confirm the requesting employee's authorization level against the Employee Authorization Matrix for the refund amount.
- Where approval is required, route the case to WAITING_FOR_APPROVAL with full evidence attached before any refund service call is made.
- Submit the refund through the approved refund service only; never adjust a payment record directly in a database or admin tool outside the service.
- After execution, verify the resulting payment status (REFUNDED or PARTIALLY_REFUNDED) before closing the case as resolved.

8. Handling Refund Service Failures

If a refund service call times out or returns an ambiguous result, the employee must not assume success or failure. The correct action is to query the authoritative payment status directly. If the payment status confirms the refund succeeded, the case can be closed. If it shows no change, the refund should be retried once; if the ambiguous result persists, escalate to Technology & Data per the Escalation Procedures rather than retrying repeatedly, which risks issuing duplicate refunds.

9. Role of OpsPilot

OpsPilot may retrieve payment transaction histories, classify the exception type using Sections 3 to 6, calculate a proposed refund amount under the Refund Policy, and prepare an approval request with the supporting evidence attached. OpsPilot must not execute a refund directly when the employee's authorization level is insufficient, and must clearly flag reconciliation exceptions as requiring Payments Operations review rather than presenting them as ordinary refund cases.

10. Related Documents

- Refund Policy — governs eligibility and amount.
- Cancellation Policy — governs order cancellation and its interaction with captured payments.
- Chargeback Handling SOP — governs disputes raised through the customer's bank.
- Employee Authorization Matrix — governs refund execution limits by role.
- Fraud & Risk Policy — governs payment exceptions connected to suspicious activity.

Synthetic environment notice: Cortora, its employees, customers, policies, and operational records are fictional and created solely for the OpsPilot engineering project.